

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Office and Administrative Assistant English

Vocabulary & phrasebook



Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Office assistants, administrative assistants, reception administrators, and team support staff.

All organizations, appointments, documents, prices, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This is not legal, financial, immigration, security, or records-retention advice. Follow the employer's actual purchasing, access, privacy, travel, and approval arrangements. Sample policies and delegated responsibilities apply only to the stated exercise.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

access permission

A setting determining whether a person may view, edit, or otherwise use a file or location.

action item

A specific task agreed at a meeting, ideally with an owner and due date.

agenda

A list of topics and their planned order for a meeting.

appointment reference

A code or identifier linking a visitor to a particular scheduled visit.

attachment

A file sent with an email or message.

attendee

A person expected to participate in a meeting or event.

backorder

An ordered item not currently supplied that remains due for later fulfillment.

booking reference

An identifier used to locate a specific travel or accommodation reservation.

buffer time

Time left between appointments for preparation, travel, or overruns.

calendar invitation

An electronic request placing a proposed meeting in participants' calendars.

callback

A return telephone call responding to an earlier call or message.

coverage

An arrangement for another worker to handle specified duties during someone's absence.

deadline

The latest agreed time by which a task or response must be completed.

delivery note

A document listing the goods a supplier states are included in a delivery.

dependency

Something another task needs before it can proceed, such as a confirmed attendee list.

direct line

A telephone number that reaches a particular person or team without going through the main reception number.

expense claim

A request for reimbursement of eligible work expenses with the required supporting details.

extension

An internal telephone number used to reach a person or department within an organization.

handover

An exchange passing current task status and outstanding work to another person.

host

The employee responsible for receiving a particular visitor.

itinerary

A schedule of travel segments and related arrangements for a trip.

message routing

Directing a telephone message to the person or team responsible for its subject.

minutes

A record of a meeting's key decisions and actions, not necessarily a word-for-word transcript.

purchase order

A document issued by an organization specifying an order for goods or services.

refundable fare

A fare allowing a refund under its stated conditions, which may include limits or charges.

requisition

An internal request for goods or services before any required purchasing approval.

shared folder

A storage location accessible to designated people for common files.

tentative hold

A temporary reservation of time that has not yet been fully confirmed.

time zone

A region's system of local clock time used when comparing meeting times across locations.

version

An identifiable revision of a document or file.

visitor badge

An identification pass issued for a visitor's permitted access.

visitor log

A record of visitors' arrival and departure details kept under the organization's stated arrangements.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Resolve the time reference before booking

Do you mean ___ in ___ time?

On that date, it will be ___ for ___.

I've placed a hold; ___ is still unconfirmed.

A calendar opening is not acceptance. State both local times for the supplied date and distinguish a hold from a confirmed meeting.

Word combinations in this lesson

place a tentative hold: reserve a proposed time without calling it confirmed

check for a conflict: identify appointments that overlap

allow a buffer: leave time between scheduled commitments

confirm the time zone: state which local clock time an invitation uses

Collect the details needed for the right recipient

Is this about ___ or ___?

Let me read that reference back: ___.

You've requested a callback by ___; I'll pass that on.

A caller's requested deadline is not a colleague's commitment. Read back ambiguous names or numbers and keep the message focused.

Word combinations in this lesson

take a message: record the caller's relevant details

read the number back: repeat a phone number to check accuracy

put a caller through: connect them to the intended recipient

confirm the purpose of the call: ask what the caller needs without requesting unnecessary private details

Close a discussion with a specific action

Who will take ___, and by when?

The agreed action is ___; no decision on ___ yet.

Can we defer ___ until ___?

Distinguish discussion, action, and decision. Obtaining quotes is not the same as approving an order.

Word combinations in this lesson

circulate the agenda: share the planned meeting topics with attendees

confirm the action owner: identify who has agreed to carry out a task

capture the decision: record what the meeting actually agreed

defer an item: move a topic to a later discussion

Correct the file and the recipient's usable access

I sent version ___; the current version is ___.

The corrected detail is ___.

Can you confirm you can view ___?

State the current revision and the consequential difference. A correct link is not useful until the intended recipient can open it.

Word combinations in this lesson

confirm the current version: identify which revision should be used

check the attachment: verify which file was actually sent

request viewing access: ask for permission to read without implying editing rights

replace an outdated link: provide a link to the intended current document

Ask a supplier about a specific mismatch

The order lists ___; we received ___.

Could you confirm whether ___?

Please give us the next update by ___ if agreed.

A document saying delivered does not establish the physical count. Ask about the two missing units without inventing their cause or arrival date.

Word combinations in this lesson

match the delivery to the order: compare received items with the stated request

report a short delivery: notify the supplier that fewer items arrived than expected

ask for a revised delivery date: request an updated arrival estimate

confirm the outstanding quantity: state how many ordered items remain undelivered

Check identity of the host without unnecessary questions

Could I check your appointment reference?

That lists ___ in ___.

Please wait here while I contact ___.

A shared first name is not enough to route a visitor. Ask for the relevant reference rather than private details unrelated to the visit.

Word combinations in this lesson

confirm the host: identify the employee expecting the visitor

check the appointment reference: match the visit to its recorded booking

issue the visitor badge: provide the appropriate pass after the required check

wait in reception: remain in the visitor area until the receiving arrangements are confirmed

Compare the actual conditions, not a broad label

Both cover ___, but their conditions differ.

Under these terms, cancellation before ___ means ___.

Neither is booked; we still need ___.

Refundable does not always mean every dollar comes back in every circumstance. Preserve the deadline and deduction attached to this fictional fare.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the fare conditions: read the rules attached to the quoted ticket

confirm the arrival station: verify the actual destination point

hold off on booking: wait before making a purchase or reservation

attach the supporting receipt: include the purchase record required for an expense request

Make the conflict specific enough to resolve

I have ___ due at ___, requiring ___.

Adding ___ means ___ will be delayed.

Which deadline can we revise with ___?

Describe the total workload and its timing, then ask the person with authority to choose. Don't quietly downgrade another person's deadline.

Word combinations in this lesson

agree the priority order: decide which task should come first

flag a dependency: identify the missing input holding up a task

hand over an open item: transfer an unfinished task with its current status

confirm coverage: check who will handle named duties during an absence

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Scheduling across calendars and time zones

A colleague asks for a 3:00 meeting with another office. For this fictional date, 3:00 in the colleague's office equals noon at the other office. The request does not identify whose time is intended. Both calendars are open at that equivalent time; confirm the intended time before sending invitations.

When you say three o'clock, do you mean three in your office's time zone? On this date, that would be noon for the other office. Both calendars are open then, but I haven't sent an invitation. Please confirm the intended local time so I can label the meeting accurately.

Try it again: One participant calls the time lunchtime. Check their local time rather than treating the phrase as a new booking request.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Taking useful calls and passing accurate messages

Caller Lena Park needs the facilities team about delivery D18, not the finance team about an invoice. Facilities extension is 214. Lena requests a callback before 4:00, but availability is unknown. Ask for the delivery reference and preferred contact route, then relay the requested deadline without promising it.

Could I confirm that your call concerns delivery D18 for facilities, rather than an invoice query for finance? I'll route the message to extension 214. Please confirm your preferred callback details. I'll include your request for a response before four, but I haven't confirmed the team's availability.

Try it again: The caller says they already spoke to accounts. Confirm whether the current question is still about physical delivery.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Preparing meetings and confirming action points

A meeting has ten minutes left and two agenda items: printer replacement and visitor signage. The chair prioritizes the printer decision. Sam can obtain two quotes by Thursday; nobody has approved a purchase. Ask the group to confirm that action and defer signage to the next meeting.

We have ten minutes left, and the chair has prioritized the printer item. Sam, can you confirm you'll obtain two quotes by Thursday? I'll record that as the action, not as purchase approval. Can we move visitor signage to the next agenda and confirm whether anyone needs that discussed sooner?

Try it again: An attendee says the minutes should list a printer purchase. Clarify the actual decision before ending.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Checking document versions and access

An assistant sent version 2 of a visitor guide, but version 3 was approved this morning. The older version has the wrong reception floor. The current guide is in the shared folder; one recipient lacks viewing access. Correct the message and request access from the document owner without widening permissions independently.

I sent version two, which gives the wrong reception floor. I'm sorry for the confusion. Version three was approved this morning and is the current guide in the shared folder. I'll send its link and ask the document owner to resolve your viewing access before you rely on the guide.

Try it again: The recipient asks you to make the whole folder public. Request the necessary limited access from its owner instead.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Querying office supplies and delivery differences

Purchase order P44 is for twelve archive boxes. The delivery note lists twelve, but the checked shipment contains ten. No second package or backorder is documented. Ask the supplier to confirm the outstanding two and whether another shipment is planned; do not approve payment or claim theft.

Purchase order P44 lists twelve archive boxes, and the delivery note also lists twelve. We received ten in the checked shipment, leaving a difference of two. Could you confirm whether another package is due or whether this is a short delivery, and give us the next update time?

Try it again: The delivery note is signed. Keep the reported physical count separate from assumptions about what the signature proves.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Welcoming visitors and checking arrangements

Visitor Taylor arrives for a 10:00 meeting with Jordan. The office has two Jordans: Jordan Chen in facilities and Jordan Patel in sales. Reference V12 names Jordan Chen. Check the reference, contact the host, and explain the reception wait; the visitor is not cleared to enter other areas alone.

We have two colleagues named Jordan, so could I check your appointment reference? V12 lists Jordan Chen in facilities. I'll contact that host now. Please wait here in reception while we confirm the receiving arrangements; I'll update you as soon as Jordan responds.

Try it again: The visitor sees someone wearing a badge and asks to follow them upstairs. Keep the host-confirmation arrangement clear.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Clarifying travel options and booking status

Two fictional rail quotes cover the same trip. A costs \$70 and is nonrefundable; B costs \$90 and permits a refund before departure with a \$10 deduction. The traveler's meeting is not confirmed. Purchasing approval is still required. Compare the supplied conditions without recommending financial or legal action.

Both quotes cover the same trip. A costs seventy dollars and is nonrefundable; B costs ninety and allows a refund before departure with ten dollars deducted. Your meeting is still unconfirmed, so that flexibility may matter. Neither option is booked, and purchasing approval is still needed before we proceed.

Try it again: The traveler says refundable means no conditions. Read back the specific deduction and before-departure limit.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Prioritizing work and handing over coverage

At 10:00 an assistant has a visitor list due at 10:30 and a room pack due at 11:00. Each needs thirty minutes. A manager requests a new twenty-minute spreadsheet check by 10:20. No colleague is free. Ask the manager to choose priorities or adjust a deadline; do not promise all three.

I have the visitor list due at ten-thirty and the room pack at eleven, each needing thirty minutes. The new check adds twenty minutes before ten-twenty, so I can't complete all three by those times. Which should take priority, and which deadline can we revise with the person waiting for it?

Try it again: The manager calls the extra task urgent without changing its duration. Ask which existing commitment should change.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Secretaries and Administrative Assistants

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/office-and-administrative-support/secretaries-and-administrative-assistants.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Secretaries and Administrative Assistants, Except Legal, Medical, and Executive

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/43-6014.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

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Lesson 01: Scheduling across calendars and time zones

Original fictional case: A colleague asks for a 3:00 meeting with another office. For this fictional date, 3:00 in the colleague's office equals noon at the other office. The request does not identify whose time is intended. Both calendars are open at that equivalent time; confirm the intended time before sending invitations.

Language workshop: Resolve the time reference before booking

Communication goal: Confirm whose clock a proposed meeting time refers to.

Language guidance: A calendar opening is not acceptance. State both local times for the supplied date and distinguish a hold from a confirmed meeting.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Do you mean ___ in ___ time? / On that date, it will be ___ for ___. / I've placed a hold; ___ is still unconfirmed.

Vocabulary: calendar invitation: An electronic request placing a proposed meeting in participants' calendars. / tentative hold: A temporary reservation of time that has not yet been fully confirmed. / time zone: A region's system of local clock time used when comparing meeting times across locations. / buffer time: Time left between appointments for preparation, travel, or overruns.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Colleague: mean three in your own office; can explain the supplied noon equivalent when asked.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: One participant calls the time lunchtime. Check their local time rather than treating the phrase as a new booking request.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: When you say three o'clock, do you mean three in your office's time zone? On this date, that would be noon for the other office. Both calendars are open then, but I haven't sent an invitation. Please confirm the intended local time so I can label the meeting accurately.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Test recall and transfer

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Review with supported choices and speaking

1. Ask me to close my notes. Prepare six four-choice questions: two vocabulary gaps, one grammar contrast, one confirmed-versus-unknown distinction, one choice of reply, and one transfer to a clearly labelled fictional variation.
2. Show only the first question. Use a short role-labelled exchange or a concrete scenario, four plausible choices A-D, and exactly one defensible answer. Stop and wait.
3. After each answer explain all options, offer one hint for a retry if needed, and invite me to say the completed exchange aloud. Only then move on. Do not request an original written response.
4. Track whether I answered independently or with a hint, not a certified proficiency score. Do not assess pronunciation from typed text. Replace ambiguous questions and accept valid spoken alternatives.
5. Give a compact review card with three four-choice recall items and a separate answer section. Summarize two specific successes and two points to revisit. Do not claim to remember or schedule future sessions.

END PROMPT